remarkably non-violent hijack in which no passengers or crew were harmed, but an ageing plane that had been out of commission and was surprisingly brought back into use days before the hijack was conveniently blown up while stationary in a Pakistani airfield).

The shadowy truths of the RAW's involvement (through the Border Security Force) in the hijacking of the Indian Airlines Fokker Friendship plane Ganga (one of the precipitating factors of the 1971 war) with which Butt had something to do, is one of those episodes in the history of modern India which has never quite seen the light of day. And Butt, too, like Afzal, may have eventually been a pawn in a game far more complex then he could have comprehended at the time. It is possible that Butt, too, like Afzal, was acting at least part of the time under orders that emanated from quarters deep within the Indian deep state. Eventually, Butt, the secular idealist, the sometime double agent, the victim of Indian as well as Pakistani justice, returned to India, was arrested and put away to be forgotten in Tihar Jail, and in the wake of Mhatre's kidnap and murder, made to walk to the gallows. While alive, he had been an obscure, little-known agitator, in death he became 'Shaheed-e-Kashmir'. He proved to be far more dangerous in his death to the Indian State then he was when he had been alive, so much so that the Indian army routinely swoops down on his village on 11 February each year to prevent his family from holding a private memorial function in his honour. His brother too was killed in an encounter, his family was prevented from coming to Delhi on the day of his execution, and all pictures or portraits of him have been taken away from the private homes of his immediate family. The cynical short-sightedness and the awkward combination of memory and forgetfulness that characterizes Indian State policy in Kashmir may once again produce another martyr, who will join Maqbool Butt in the pantheon of shahadat.

I abhor martyrdom, and following Bertolt Brecht, can only 'pity the people who need heroes'. Yet, it is the tragic destiny of Kashmir that the history of the subcontinent will offer them a harvest of martyrs every season. In death, their biographies become abstracted to conform to a monotonous pattern of resistance, imprisonment and violent death. Each of these individuals would have been valuable human beings if they were alive. Often they are, like Mohammad Afzal, sensitive and intelligent persons, someone who wanted to be a doctor, or someone who liked literature and was considered by his peers to be one of the ablest of his generation.